speak through this novel technology of the book. There is one specific book whose many chapters allegedly contain all the divine words about everything from the creation of the universe to food regulations. Crucially, no priest, prophet or human institution can forget or change these divine words, because you can always compare what the fallible humans are telling you with what the infallible book records.

But religions of the book had their own set of problems. Most obviously, who decides what to include in the holy book? The first copy didn't come down from heaven. It had to be compiled by humans. Still, the faithful hoped that this thorny problem could be solved by a once-and-for-all supreme effort. If we could get together the wisest and most trustworthy humans, and they could all agree on the contents of the holy book, from that moment onward we could excise humans from the loop, and the divine words would forever be safe from human interference.

Many objections can be raised against this procedure: who selects the wisest humans? On the basis of what criteria? What if they cannot reach a consensus? What if they later change their minds? Nevertheless, this was the procedure used to compile holy books like the Hebrew Bible.

THE MAKING OF THE HEBREW BIBLE

During the first millennium BCE, Jewish prophets, priests and scholars produced an extensive collection of stories, documents, prophecies, poems, prayers and chronicles. The Bible as a single holy book didn't exist in biblical times. King David and the prophet Isaiah never saw a copy of the Bible.

It is sometimes claimed, erroneously, that the oldest surviving copy of the Bible comes from the Dead Sea Scrolls. These scrolls are a collection of about nine hundred different documents, written mostly in the last two centuries BCE and found in various caves around Qumran, a village near the Dead Sea.[8] Most scholars believe they constituted the archive of a Jewish sect that lived nearby.[9]

Significantly, none of the scrolls contains a copy of the Bible, and no scroll indicates that the twenty-four books of the Old Testament were considered a single and complete database. Some of the scrolls certainly record texts that are today part of the canonical Bible. For example,